"The perception, created with huge effort and expenditure, made everyone believe that there is no alternative to Baghel," says journalist Sunil Kumar. "Even though the Congress had made numerous promises, it seems the corruption allegations took a toll. Congress leaders said corruption is not an issue in Chhattisgarh. Well, if it was an issue the Congress raised in Karnataka, why would it not be an issue in Chhattisgarh?" That is perhaps the most illustrative example of how the Baghel government misread its challenges.

Ironically, it was the Congress that had first set the agenda in Chhattisgarh. Baghel in his poll strategy focused mainly on the OBCs and rural Chhattisgarh. The main contest, in his mind, was going to be in the OBC-dominated central region, or the plains, where agriculture is the key economic activity and which, at 64, has the maximum number of seats. To counter the BJP's Hindutva plank, Baghel was betting on his own 'soft Hindutva' and 'Chhattisgarhiat'. This was barely enough, though, for the BJP had a lot more in its arsenal.

THE CONGRESS FAILED TO FULLY GRASP THE IMPORT OF THE CORRUPTION CHARGES. INSIDERS SAY THE ED ACTION WAS AIMED AT NOT JUST TAINTING THE BAGHEL GOVERNMENT BUT ALSO AT CUTTING OFF THE PARTY'S FINANCING

THE BJP CHARGE

It started with organisational changes in August 2022, when Bilaspur MP Arun Sao was appointed the state BJP chief and Narayan Chandel became the leader of the Opposition. The messaging was critical: while Sao is from the Sahu community, which accounts for 14 per cent of the population and is the biggest OBC group in the state, Chandel belongs to the Kurmi caste, the same as Baghel. The intent was to counter the Congress's OBC pitch, but it came with a parallel benefit: within rural Chhattisgarh, Sahus and Kurmis compete with each other for power, and the BJP in a way thus extended a hand of friendship to the Sahus. True, in appointing Sao, it did replace tribal politician Vishnu Deo Sai, but the Congress's attempts to draw attention to that fact did little to dent the BJP's tribal vote. It swept the tribal-dominated North and South Chhattisgarh, winning all 14 seats in the north, and eight out of 12 in the south. In total, the BJP won 17 of the state's 29 ST-reserved seats, up from just three in 2018, and 40 per cent of the ST vote.

The biggest BJP salvo came in October, when the Enforcement Directorate (ED) began a crackdown on an alleged coal scam, as part of which it reeled in IAS officer Sameer Vishnoi and deputy secretary to the CM, Saumya Chaurasia. Insiders say the action was aimed at not just playing up corruption charges but also cutting off the Congress's financing. A liquor scam and the Mahadev app scandal were added to that mix, creating a perfect storm for the Congress in which even Baghel and other senior leaders got caught.

By then, it had already been two months since the BJP announced its first list of candidates for the 21 seats that it had been losing in previous elections. The early start paid off, as the party ended up winning in 10 of these 21 constituencies. The BJP also calculated its odds well in retaining old leaders. Out of its 14 sitting MLAs in the outgoing assembly, the BJP denied tickets to only two. At the same time, of its total 90 candidates, 55 were fresh faces. "The party had learnt a lesson from Karnataka where it denied tickets to a large number of sitting MLAs and faced infighting," says a former BJP MLA. "This time, it was decided not to try something very radical and give reasonable leverage to the old guard."

The Congress, on the other hand, could do little to contain the internecine war between CM Baghel and his deputy T.S. Singhdeo. Even during ticket distribution, the two clashed over promoting their own loyalists, at the cost of winnability. The marginalisation of Singhdeo in home turf Ambikapur, allegedly at the behest of Baghel, also weakened the Congress in the region.

The BJP also adopted a seat-wise strategy wherein it allegedly supported candidates who could cut into the Congress vote. Candidates from reserved groups, both tribals and SCs, contested from general seats. In South Chhattisgarh, especially in Narayanpur and Chitrakot, there were multiple candidates, and NOTA was one of the most favoured options. This was no coincidence. For example, in January this year, communal tension broke out in Narayanpur over the conversion of some tribals to Christianity. The converts faced violence, and they felt the protection extended by the state was inadequate. Tribal Christians felt alienated, and state Congress chief Deepak Baij ended up losing his Chitrakot seat, where the total votes polled by AAP, Independents and NOTA were higher than his defeat margin. In Narayanpur, a large number of votes were NOTA.

GOP'S LOST CHANCE

Where the Congress could have gained an edge over the BJP was in its 'soft Hindutva'-peddling. With his Ram Van Gaman Path and invocation of Chhattisgarhiat, Baghel had initially neutralised the BJP's Hindutva cannon. But the Congress failed to utilise that advantage, and the BJP came up with other tricks. It capitalised on the two Hindu-Muslim riots in the state, one in October 2021 in Kawardha and the other in neighbouring Bemetara in April this year. In Kawardha, the party fielded Vijay Sharma, an accused in the incident, against state forest minister and the outgoing assembly's sole Muslim MLA Mohammed Akbar, who won the 2018 polls with almost 60,000 votes, the highest margin for anyone in